POLITE COMPANY

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Short Film Version / Irish Production

Written by

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Adapted from *Polite Company*, a feature-length screenplay by the author.

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FIRST DRAFT

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INT. O'CONNELL BEDROOM - DAY

We open close on KEVIN (mid 40's, our protagonist, uncomfortable, in suit) adjusting a tie, in front of a full length mirror. Tugging at the collar. Maybe it's slightly too tight. Not badly fitted. Just wrong enough that wearing it looks like work.

COLLEEN, (late 60s, Kevin's mother) comes in, makeup and dress, crucifix around neck. She comes in and hugs him.

COLLEEN
Thanks again for doing this, sweetie.

KEVIN
Yeah, well... Christmas is your day, right? But it's... it's just the one dinner.

COLLEEN
Of course.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - DINING ROOM - DAY

Christmas Dinner.

Places:

* Head: RORY (70s, Patriarch)
* Right head: COLLEEN
* Right middle: Cousin DECLAN (late 30s, unexamined masculinity)
* Right end: MAUREEN (mid-30s unquestioned femininity. Declan's fiancee)
* Left head: KEVIN
* Left middle: Aunt MEGAN (late 60s, outspoken, irrepressible)
* Left End: Uncle SHANE (80s, irrepressibly kind, cognitive decline.)
* End: Father PATRICK (late-50s, Catholic Priest. Silent, Intimidating.)

Two turkeys. One oven-roasted to perfection. The fried one is over-charred on one side, blistered, warped and slightly collapsed. Not grotesque. Clearly wrong.

Plates pass. Everyone’s already eating.

RORY
I think the fried turkey came out alright. Bit darker than expected, but that's the oil temp. Locks in the flavour.

DECLAN
(supportive)
Looks savage.

MAUREEN
So, Declan tells me you work at a food bank, Colleen?

COLLEEN
Mm. Yes -- Our Mother Of Mercy. With Father Patrick.

Patrick silently nods acknowledgement.

MAUREEN
What's it like?

COLLEEN
Exhausting, honestly. It seems like every year, there are more people who need help.

DECLAN
Yeah, people are struggling. Not much you can do.

Kevin slow blinks.

KEVIN
I wouldn't say that--

MAUREEN
What would you say?

KEVIN
When wages don't keep up with--

COLLEEN
Kevin, this is Christmas. Is this the time for politics?

KEVIN
I'm not--

RORY
We'll agree to disagree.

Forks clink. Someone chews too loudly.

KEVIN
Sorry. I didn't mean--

RORY
Let's not get into it.

Shane smiles, confused.

SHANE
People used to help their neighbours more.

DECLAN
Exactly.

Kevin nods. Picks up his fork. Doesn't eat.

DECLAN (cont'd)
People just want stability. Not handouts. Just a fair shot.

Kevin's fork hovers. He doesn't bite.

SHANE
You used to raise a family on one income.

COLLEEN
Exactly.

KEVIN
People still want that life. They just can't afford it.

RORY
Kevin. That's enough.

COLLEEN
Why are you so angry all the time?

KEVIN
I'm not angry.

The table stills.

COLLEEN
We just don't want a fight.

KEVIN
I know.

RORY
Okay, okay, everyone breathe.

Silence. Forks on plates.

Father Patrick stares at Kevin over a slow sip of coffee. Kevin shrinks.

COLLEEN
You've always been... sensitive.
(beat)
I mean that kindly.

KEVIN
I'm not--

Kevin looks to Megan.

MEGAN
I'd say... empathetic? Not--

MAUREEN
Histrionic?

MEGAN
Right. We could use more sensitivity. Wouldn't you agree, Father Patrick?

Father Patrick slowly nods. No warmth.

SHANE
I'm sensitive too. Switched toothpaste. It'd be hell for me living in America with the ice cold beer. Kevin, they do serve beer cold in America, don't they?

KEVIN
They ice it to death. It's not meant to be tasted. It's meant to be light. Clean.
(beat)
Unobtrusive.

MEGAN
More palatable for consumption.

Kevin nods.

MEGAN (cont'd)
Pass the mash?

MAUREEN
So, when will you be moving back home?

KEVIN
Not planning to at the moment.

DECLAN
So you're going to stay there?

KEVIN
Not sure, but I don't have plans to move back.

MAUREEN
God. I couldn't live in the States.

RORY
All the guns, and the crime. And what happens if you get sick?

KEVIN
My job's there. And it pays well enough. With good insurance.

RORY
O'Grady's looking for a fellow who can manage the Lidl. I could put in a good word.

KEVIN
Dad. I'm a *software engineer*.

RORY
I don't think he'd hold that against you. Just tell 'em you work with computers.

Kevin inhales. His hand trembles as he lifts his water glass. He sets it down carefully.

Sound drops slightly. Conversation continues, muffled.

The camera stays on Kevin as the room moves without him.

MEGAN (O.S.)
This is very good.

SHANE (O.S.)
Did I get the good seat this year?

COLLEEN (O.S.)
Anyone need salt or pepper?

SMASH MATCH CUT:

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME — DINING ROOM — LATER

Kevin hasn’t moved. Dinner has become coffee and dessert. Mince pies, Xmas puds, trifle, whipped cream, plates. Ceramic scrapes loudly in the quiet.

COLLEEN
Kevin?

Colleen is holding a pie cutter. Kevin startles.

KEVIN
Oh -- no, thank you.

COLLEEN
You sure? Suit yourself.

SHANE
I'll have whatever's easiest on the stomach.

COLLEEN
Trifle it is.

Father Patrick drinks his coffee black. Silent.

RORY
This turned out nice.

Murmurs of agreement.

Kevin stares at his empty plate. Sighs. Almost over.

COLLEEN
Oh, Kevin -- I watched your stand-up set online. I liked it.

Kevin's brow furrows. Not flattered. *Dread*.

KEVIN
You did?

COLLEEN
I did. Why don't you pull it up on the big TV? Show everyone.

Kevin freezes.

KEVIN
Mam... is that a good idea?

COLLEEN
Why wouldn't it be?

KEVIN
My set isn't exactly for polite company.

COLLEEN
Oh, I didn't mind.

Kevin is terrified. His voice trembles. Struggles to get the words out.

KEVIN
Mam... it's not just the jokes.

COLLEEN
You mean the dress?

Kevin blinks, shocked.

KEVIN
Uh--

Colleen pours coffee.

COLLEEN
Oh, don't worry. Everyone in the family knows.

Silence.

KEVIN
Everyone... *knows*.

Kevin scans the faces. Megan is stunned. Everyone else already knows, and doesn't see what the big deal is.

COLLEEN
Well, once you told your aunt Megan, I figured family was fine.

Kevin looks over to Megan. Megan is also shocked, and shakes her head "no." As if to say: "I didn't do this."

KEVIN
(soft)
You told them. *Before dinner*.
(pause)
Before... before you asked me to wear the suit. Before you told me to just... be Kevin for one day.

A half-beat.

Shane snaps his fingers.

SHANE
That's what I forgot to tell you! I knew it was important. Right, Kevin -- congratulations on coming out.
(beat)
Is this just a trans woman for the act, or... is this like your life now? Like, are you Kevin here and Kelly in America?

Kevin doesn't answer.

She stares into her coffee. Steam curls upward.

Colleen adds a scoop of vanilla ice cream to a mince pie and slides it over to Kevin.

Kevin looks at the pie. Then up at Colleen.

Colleen smiles maternally at Kevin, looking down at her.

CUT TO BLACK.